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WOODEN KNIFE

The Romanian communist leader Gheorghe Gheorghiu-Dej, who made a stopover in Moscow on October 23 on his way back from a state visit to Indonesia, found Khrushchev in a highly agitated if not panicky state. Khrushchev was extremely upset when his minister of defense, Marshal Malinovsky, reported that the US Navy was on high alert and that preparations for a blockade of Cuba were underway. According to the recollections of Gheorghiu-Dej, who was present when Malinovsky reported the news, and whose words were relayed later by one of the Romanian intelligence chiefs, Ion Mihai Pacepa, “Khrushchev flew into a rage, yelling, cursing and issuing an avalanche of contradictory orders.”

The Romanians suspected that Khrushchev had been drinking that morning, but they were wrong. The Soviet leader was exhausted for lack of sleep: Gheorghiu-Dej arrived right after the marathon all-night session that saw Khrushchev first brace himself for nuclear war in the event of an American invasion of Cuba and then decide how to react to the